5. Find the 5th root of

(i) 32 (ii) 243 (iii) 100000 (iv) $\frac{1024}{3125}$

2.6 Surds

Having familiarized with the concept of Real numbers, representing them on the number line and manipulating them, we now learn about surds, a distinctive way of representing certain approximate values.

Can you simplify $\sqrt{4}$ and remove the $\sqrt{\ }$ symbol? Yes; one can replace $\sqrt{4}$ by the number 2. How about $\sqrt{\frac{1}{9}}$? It is easy; without $\sqrt{\ }$ symbol, the answer is $\frac{1}{3}$. What about $\sqrt{0.01}$?. This is also easy and the solution is 0.1

In the cases of $\sqrt{4}$, $\sqrt{\frac{1}{9}}$ and $\sqrt{0.01}$, you can resolve to get a solution and make sure that the symbol $\sqrt{\ }$ is not seen in your solution. Is this possible at all times?

Consider $\sqrt{18}$. Can you evaluate it and also remove the radical symbol? Surds are unresolved radicals, such as square root of 2, cube root of 5, etc.

They are irrational roots of equations with rational coefficients.

A surd is an irrational root of a rational number. $\sqrt[n]{a}$ is a surd, provided $n \in \mathbb{N}$, $n > 1$, 'a' is rational.

Examples : $\sqrt{2}$ is a surd. It is an irrational root of the equation $x^2 = 2$. (Note that $x^2 - 2 = 0$ is an equation with rational coefficients. $\sqrt{2}$ is irrational and may be shown as $1.4142135\ldots$ a non-recurring, non-terminating decimal).

$\sqrt[3]{3}$ (which is same as $3^{\frac{1}{3}}$) is a surd since it is an irrational root of the equation $x^3 - 3 = 0$. ($\sqrt{3}$ is irrational and may be shown as $1.7320508\ldots$ a non-recurring, non-terminating decimal).

You will learn solving (quadratic) equations like $x^2 - 6x + 7 = 0$ in your next class. This is an equation with rational coefficients and one of its roots is $3 + \sqrt{2}$, which is a surd.

Is $\sqrt{\frac{1}{25}}$ a surd? No; it can be simplified and written as rational number $\frac{1}{5}$. How about $\sqrt[4]{\frac{16}{81}}$? It is not a surd because it can be simplified as $\frac{2}{3}$.

The famous irrational number π is not a surd! Though it is irrational, it cannot be expressed as a rational number under the $\sqrt{\ }$ symbol. (In other words, it is not a root of any equation with rational co-efficients).

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